3. Alternative Questions

These questions offer the listener a closed choice of two or more possible answers, presuming that only one is true. They are framed with the word 'or'. For e.g. Shall I meet him today or tomorrow? / Would you like to have tea, coffee or juice? Are you going to spend your vacation in Ooty or Kodaikanal? / Did you buy a sedan or a hatchback?

4. Tag Questions

A tag question is a short question form added at the end of a declarative or an imperative sentence. It is generally used to draw the attention of the listener to the sentence and to seek confirmation. Sometimes they are used to encourage a reply from the person who is spoken to. Tag questions are commonly used in conversations and not usually in formal English.

Points to remember while framing tag questions

- The question tag always begins with an auxiliary verb or a modal verb. Question tags are formed with the same auxiliary or modal verb found in the main part of the sentence.
- The subject of the question tag is a personal pronoun (except 'there'), which is a substitute for the subject of the statement.
- The pronoun should agree with the number, gender and person of the subject of the statement.
- The negative adverb 'not' is always used in contracted form.

[isn't, wasn't, aren't, weren't, hasn't, haven't, hadn't, doesn't, don't, didn't, won't, shan't, can't, wouldn't, shouldn't, couldn't, mustn't, needn't, oughtn't, daren't]

- If the statement is in the affirmative, the tag it takes is usually negative. If the statement is negative, the tag it takes is positive.

e.g. Mr. Ranjith is a great scholar, **isn't he**?

You **can** complete this project in a week, **can't you**?

e.g. Ahalya **will never** accept your proposal, **will she**?

- If the main part of the sentence doesn't have an auxiliary verb or a modal verb, the question tag is formed with the appropriate form of 'do' based on the tense of the main verb and the number of the subject.

e.g. Mahathi **sings** very well, **doesn't she**?

(present tense – singular subject)

These girls **sing** very well, **don't they**?

(present tense – plural subject)

Mahathi **sang** very well yesterday, **didn't she**?

(past tense – singular subject)

These girls **sang** very well yesterday, **didn't they**?

(past tense - plural subject)

- The subject hidden in an imperative sentence is always 'you' and so the subject of the question tag is also 'you'.
- Imperative sentences that express a polite request, obligation, suggestion, invitation, impatience, warning etc.

12th General_English_Unit_3_A_Prose.indd 79 13-02-2020 16:38:05